

The King's Voice - Exodus 1 (Handout)

The King's Voice

A Group Study on Exodus 1:15-22

15 Then the king of Egypt said to the Hebrew midwives, one of whom was named Shiphrah and the other Puah, **16** "When you serve as midwife to the Hebrew women and see them on the birthstool, if it is a son, you shall kill him, but if it is a daughter, she shall live." **17** But the midwives feared God and did not do as the king of Egypt commanded them, but let the male children live. **18** So the king of Egypt called the midwives and said to them, "Why have you done this, and let the male children live?" **19** The midwives said to Pharaoh, "Because the Hebrew women are not like the Egyptian women, for they are vigorous and give birth before the midwife comes to them." **20** So God dealt well with the midwives. And the people multiplied and grew very strong. **21** And because the midwives feared God, he gave them families. **22** Then Pharaoh commanded all his people, "Every son that is born to the Hebrews you shall cast into the Nile, but every daughter you shall let live." (*Exodus 1:15-22, ESV*)

A Quick Background

Joseph's family had lived in Egypt for generations and now numbered hundreds of thousands. A new, suspicious Pharaoh — likely of the 18th Dynasty, around the 1500s BC — decided to cut the Hebrew population by killing the boys, starting with a secret order to two midwives. Notice: the Bible never names this Pharaoh. Egyptian kings built monuments so their names would last forever; God decided otherwise. The "birthstool" (Hebrew *ovnayim*, literally "two stones") was the pair of bricks on which Egyptian women delivered. And "feared God" does not mean terrified of God — it means the settled conviction that God's voice is the voice that finally counts.

Introduction

We live in a world of voices. Some are kind. Some are loud. A body that says, "you're not what you used to be." A calendar that says, "your turn is over." A culture that whispers, "you're in the way." Today we meet two ordinary women caught between the loudest voice in the world and the voice of God. What they did changed the story. The question today is simple: **whose voice do you answer to?**

1. The Loud Voice (vv.15-16, 22)

Pharaoh's command is cold, absolute, bureaucratic. He doesn't debate; he issues orders. And notice how the loud voice *escalates*: first forced labor (1:11), then secret killing (1:16), then a public decree to all Egypt (1:22). The loud voice gets louder as it fails.

For us: Loud voices today rarely wear crowns, but they still claim more authority than they've earned. A diagnosis can start to sound like a verdict. Loss can sound like the final word. Culture says old is in the way, that limited is useless. Pharaoh's voice was the loudest in Egypt — but it was not the last. *Loud does not mean final.*

Questions

1. What "loud voice" is speaking too loudly in your life this season?
 2. Have you noticed that the loudest voices are often the most insecure?
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2. The Quiet Voice (v.17)

The midwives don't give a speech. They don't start a revolution. They fear God and keep doing their ordinary work — and refuse to cross a line. *They let the male children live.* That's it. No rally. No announcement. One of the most consequential acts of faith in the Bible is also one of the quietest.

For us: Most of us will never face a Pharaoh. But every day we face smaller moments where two voices compete. A sharp word swallowed. An aide thanked. A neighbor visited. A grandchild told the truth. A prayer whispered in a chair. These are the birthing stones of our age — ordinary work, quiet choices, one life at a time let to live. Fear of God doesn't always look brave. Sometimes it looks exactly like keeping on doing your ordinary, faithful work with God as your real boss.

Questions

1. What is *your* ordinary work right now — the small, daily thing God has given you?
 2. When two voices compete in your life, what helps God's quiet voice stay loud enough to hear?
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3. The Lasting Voice (vv.20-21)

"So God dealt well with the midwives... because the midwives feared God, he gave them families." Literally, "he built them houses" — the language usually reserved for kings (2 Samuel 7:11). And here is the stunning thing: Pharaoh, the god-king who built monuments so his name would last forever, is not named in the Bible. Not once. But *Shiphrah* and *Puah*? Forever. Read in every language for 3,000 years. God kept what the world forgot.

For us: Many of you have done a lifetime of work the world never noticed — children raised, a spouse cared for, prayers no one thanked you for, kindnesses no one recorded. The world doesn't have a file on you. Heaven does. The God who named Shiphrah and Puah knows your name. *"Your Father who sees in secret will reward you"* (Matthew 6:4).

Questions

1. Pharaoh's monuments didn't save his name; the midwives' ordinary work did. What does that tell you about what God keeps?
 2. How does it change this week to know the God who named Shiphrah and Puah knows your name?
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For Reflection This Week

Listen for the voices. When you feel discouraged or small, ask: *whose voice is this?* The loud voice of culture, or body, or regret — or the quiet voice of the God who has the last word? Name the loud voice for what it is. Then say softly to yourself, *"loud is not final."*

Live as one who is named. You are not forgotten. Every ordinary act of faithfulness this week — a prayer, a kindness, a phone call, a smile — is written down where it counts. The God who named Shiphrah and Puah is keeping your name too.